

Table 5 — Steering Notes for the Moderator

BENQODHI Day 2 morning round tables · 11 September 2026

For whoever steers the Table 5 discussion. Not for distribution to the plenary.

What success looks like

By the end of the session the table should be able to state, in plain language a programme officer would accept:

- **named instruments** that could support the repository now, and what is missing;
- a **route to federate** what already exists;
- the **policy value** of this kind of output, expressed as a problem a DG or funding authority actually has;
- **one recommendation.**

One concrete recommendation with a named mechanism beats five aspirations.

How to open (5 minutes)

- State the frame once: *this table is about what makes the repository last and what it is worth to policy, not about which scientific problems belong in it.* Tables 1–3 own the problems. If the table drifts into debating specific problems, redirect immediately — it is the most common failure mode for this table.
- State the logic in one breath: the repository exists first for the **scientific community**, to make comparison and sharing normal; that only holds if contributing pays, which is where **funding agencies and regulation** come in; so the two questions are which instruments can carry it, and what it is worth from a policy point of view.
- Say what is out of scope: designing the software, choosing a hosting platform in detail, agreeing legal text.

Steering main question 1 — what makes it last

1. **Force the "now vs. near future" split early.** Draw two columns on paper and assign every proposal to one. What needs nothing new can go into the recommendation; the rest belongs in the roadmap.
2. **Push for named instruments, not categories.** "European funding" is not an answer. Ask which specific programme, call type, infrastructure or institution could host, fund or maintain this, and who in the room can open that door. Capture names of instruments and names of people separately.
3. **Treat federation as a real design question, not a slogan.** Benchmark collections, open-data repositories and research infrastructures already exist. Ask concretely: which ones, what would BENQODHI have to adopt from them (identifiers, metadata, licensing, deposit routes), and what would each side have

to agree to? A federated route is usually cheaper and more credible than a new platform — but only if someone names the partners.

4. **Ask who pays for year three.** Anyone can fund a launch. Make the table say what keeps the repository alive after seed money ends — host institution, embedded infrastructure, consortium contributions, in-kind maintenance — and what happens if nothing does.

Steering main question 2 — the policy value

1. **Make them answer from the funder's side of the table.** The useful question is not "why is this good for science" but *what problem does a DG or national authority have that this solves?* Push until the answer is stated as their problem: deciding where to invest under uncertainty, justifying spend, avoiding funding the same groundwork repeatedly, telling reproducible progress from unverifiable claims.
2. **Get concrete about where it touches the procedure.** Ask which specific point in the cycle: call preparation and topic text, evidence inside a proposal, project reporting, data management plans, or evaluation of results after the fact. Different entry points need different owners — name them.
3. **Keep the funding language defensible.** If someone proposes that repository alignment should give a proposal extra points, steer it back: funders cannot apply criteria outside those published in the call. The usable version is *repository alignment as verifiable evidence under criteria that already exist* (excellence, methodology, impact, open science, reproducibility), or as something a funder could choose to write into topic text. This distinction is what makes the recommendation credible rather than naive — protect it.
4. **Use the investment-steering argument carefully.** "Fair comparison guides investment" is the strongest policy argument available here, and also the easiest to overstate. Ask what would have to be true for a funder to *rely* on the evidence: strong baselines, reproducible runs, versioned instances, independent curation. Without those, the argument collapses under scrutiny in the plenary.
5. **Test the incentive honestly.** Ask each participant: *would you personally deposit your problem definitions, data and baselines?* If the honest answer is no, ask what would change it. Credit mechanisms — citable, versioned, attributed contributions, DOIs, authorship on the benchmark — usually surface here.

Across both

1. **Raise the objections yourself if nobody does.** The three that will come up later anyway: competitive sensitivity and IP; the burden of depositing; who decides what gets accepted.
2. **Watch the interface with Table 4.** Ask at least once: *what does Table 4 need from us, and what do we need from them?* Their technical requirements and this table's instruments have to fit together. The credibility conditions in point 8 are largely Table 4's output.

3. **Timebox and land it.** Suggested split: 5 min framing, 40 min main question 1 (instruments now, near future, federation), 40 min main question 2 (policy value, funding procedures, fair comparison, incentives), 15 min transversal governance, 10 min agreeing the single recommendation and what the rapporteur will say. Reserve the last 10 minutes even if the discussion is still lively.
4. **Get the recommendation written, not described.** Before the table breaks, have the note taker read it aloud from the screen. If it cannot be read aloud in two sentences, it is not finished. Remind the note takers to push to the repository at the halfway point, not at the end.

Questions to put to specific people

- Anyone with funding-agency or programme experience: *what would stop a funder from pointing to this repository, and what would remove that obstacle?*
- Anyone from a research infrastructure or existing repository: *could you host or federate this, and under what conditions?*
- Anyone from industry R&D: *what would make you contribute rather than only consume?*

Traps to avoid

- Letting the table redesign the benchmark methodology (that is Table 4).
- Accepting "more funding is needed" as a recommendation.
- Proposing a brand-new platform when federating an existing one would do.
- Arguing the policy value only in terms of scientific benefit, without naming the funder's own problem.
- Over-claiming influence on evaluation outcomes — it will be challenged in the plenary and it weakens the rest of the argument.
- Ending with a list of everything possible instead of one thing that will happen.

Full question set and background: `table-guide.md` in this folder, and the [participant guide](#).